



2026 Player Development Programme (PDP)

Guidelines

Keeping the net wide!

What is the LGFA Player Development Programme?

AIM

To equip players with the knowledge, skills, and attitude to be the best they can be and foster a sporting vocation ('Love') for our sport.

OBJECTIVES

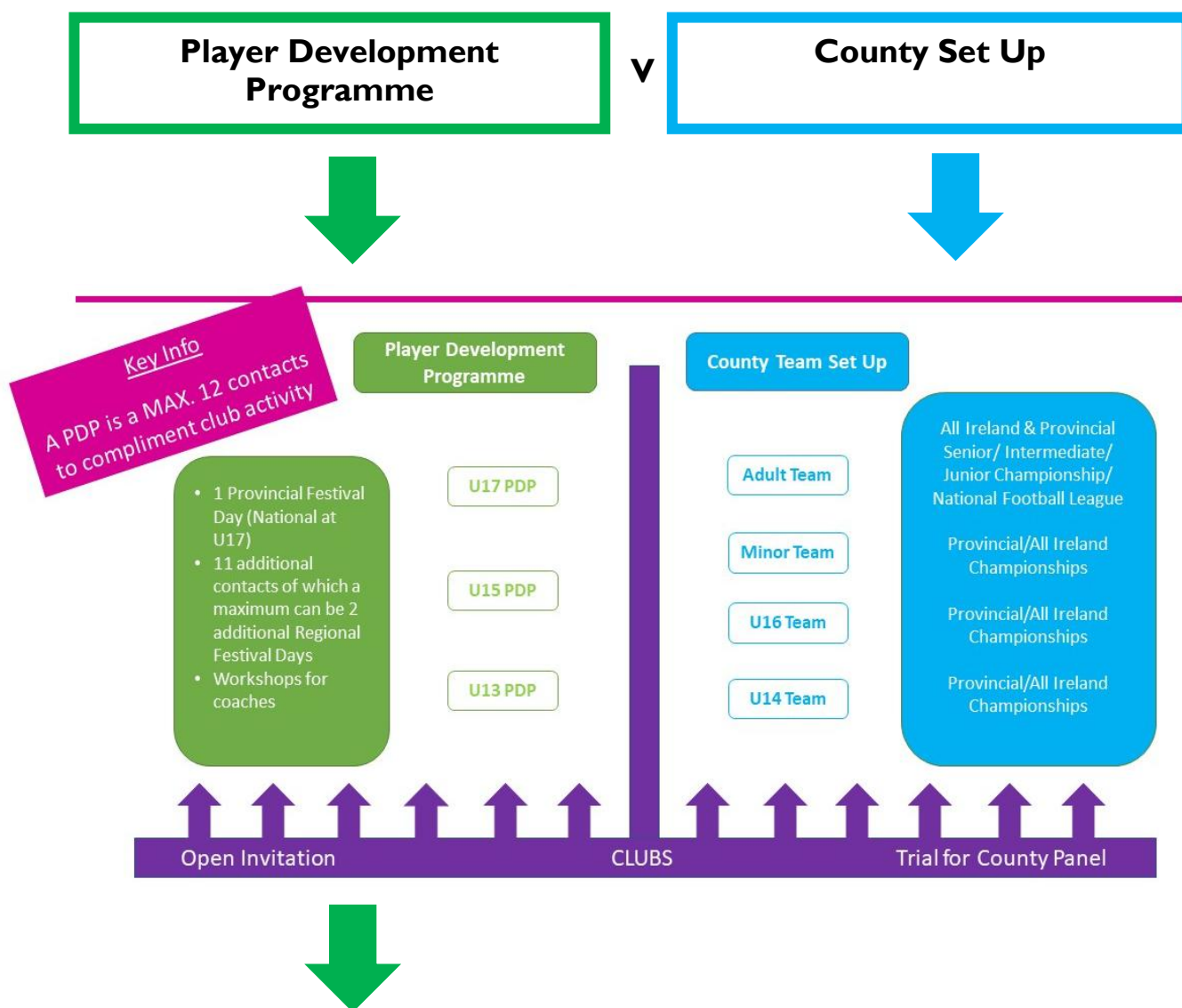
- **Dynamic and effective** in its delivery to maximise potential of all players.
- An **inclusive** programme for all players, focusing on players at various stages of development.
- Provide an opportunity for **players to develop individually**, with different players, learn new skills, and develop the fundamental skills in a positive and safe environment.
- Expose players to **high quality coaching experiences** that are in line with demands of our game i.e., technical, tactical, physical, and psycho/social.
- Focus on **coach development** and create awareness of good coaching structures and methods.
- Assist in **monitoring players participation** over a period.
- Create good **County and Club relationships**.

BENEFITS

- Clear PURPOSE associated with the LGFA Player Development Programme Objectives and method of delivery are in line with our key principles
- Promotion of developmental playing opportunities to provide the opportunity for players to showcase their skills i.e., different game formats and develop coaches.
- Strengthen participation while reducing the barriers facing organising units, such as finance and resources, so that our objectives may still be achieved.
- Limit disruption to club football and other player commitments.
- Prioritise the sharing of coaching knowledge and the mentoring of coaches, ensuring these activities sit prominently on the agenda for these programmes.
- Utilise other metrics to monitor player improvement.

Player Development Programme & County Set Up

What is the difference?



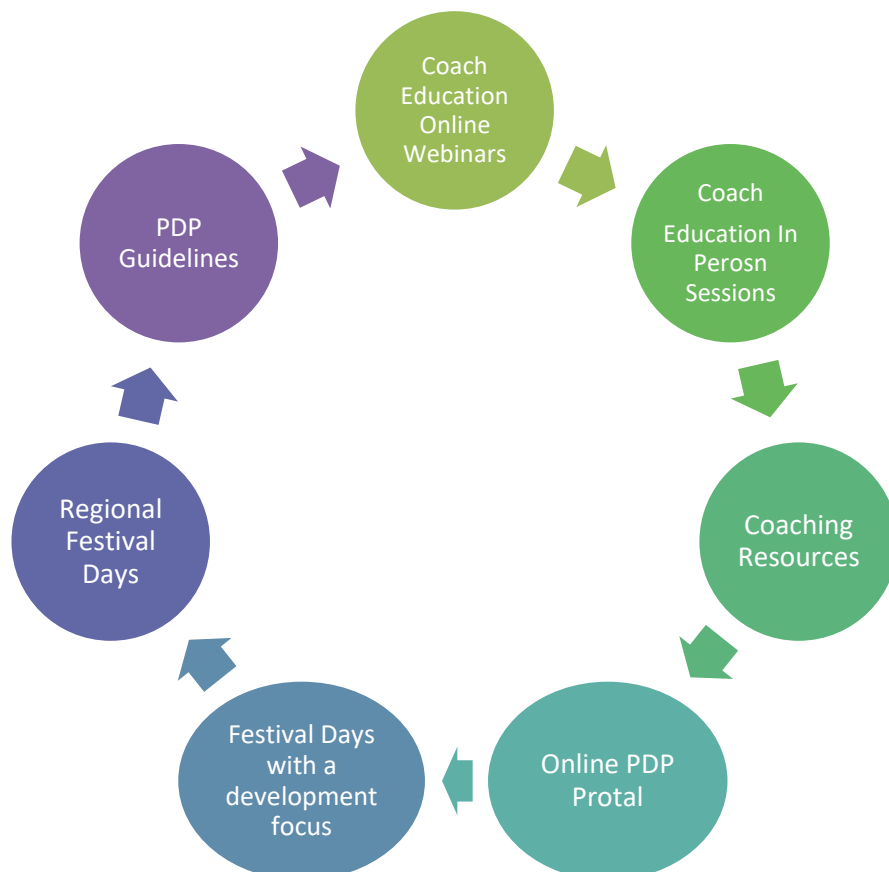
The Player Development Programme involves...

- **No** trials or selection/de-selection process – Counties can adopt a regional programme to encourage greater participation i.e., North, South etc.
- **Non-competitive** U13 & U15 Provincial/Regional Festival Days
- **Non-competitive** National U17 Festival Day with a developmental focus
- Commences no earlier than **1st February** and completed no later than **1st October** within the calendar year.

What are the Benefits of the LGFA Player Development Programme?



What support will Coaches receive during the LGFA Player Development Programme?



What are the Key Considerations for a County?



*See FAQ section for more information in relation to costs.

IMPORTANT TO NOTE:

To avoid confusion...

- Titles 'LGFA Development Academy' or 'LGFA Academy Programme' are now defunct and are **no longer permitted** to be utilised by Counties

The LGFA allow a maximum of **2** playing opportunities per region at U13/U15/U17 level outside what has been outlined.

- *A playing opportunity is defined as a non-competitive event involving 1 host County/Province inviting no more than 3 additional Counties.*

What are the Structures Associated with Each Age Group?

U13 & U15 Player Development Programme

Regionalised County Based programme.

Number of Sessions / Quality over Quantity

Maximum 12 contact days

- One of these days is your Provincial/National Festival Day. The other 11 contact sessions can be one the following:
 - **2** County or regional Festival Days (Hosts and no more than 3 invited counties) plus 9 PDP coaching sessions
 - **1** County or regional Festival Day (Hosts and no more than 3 invited counties) plus 10 PDP coaching sessions
 - **11** PDP coaching sessions
 - **Note, a County may decide to conduct less than 12 contact sessions also.**

Need to be creative when planning content to ensure cater for all key areas of development every time meet players.

? Time of year (When should PDP Commence / Conclude)

- o **To be decided by County to**
 - Not disrupt club fixtures, maximise club participation and not coincide with other development initiatives.
 - Tie in with Provincial/Regional Player Development Programme Festival Days

NOTE:

- Full Programme cannot commence until 1st February and must be completed by 1st October within a calendar year. All Counties must sign up to the PDP Pledge prior to commencement of the programme.

? Who can attend?

- o **Open invite to all non-county players. A player who has made a County panel at U14, 16 and 18 grades within the calendar year are not eligible for the PDP.**
- o Inclusive based on County capacity for coach / player ratio (min 1:8/max 1:10) (Players registered with a county panel cannot be selected to take part in the PDP programme)
- o The capacity should be set according to County resources, however, should **not** involve a selection process i.e., trials. PDP should aim to have representation from all clubs i.e., clubs to nominate X number of players each according to number of coaches available.

- o Clubs should also be encouraged/requested to send in 1 mentor which will
 - Increase capacity.
 - Be a mechanism for coach development and collaboration within the County!
 - Could apply a ratio – for every 4 players a club sends into the PDP, they must provide one mentor (1:4)

□ Playing Opportunities

- o At least one Provincial/Regional PDP Festival Day for each age grade will be organised by the Provincial Development Officer
- o The PDP Festival Day will be open to all players participating on the programme. No de-selecting of players permitted.
- o Festival Day will maximise number of teams on the day by utilising different game formats if required i.e., 9v9, 11v11, 15 v 15. This will assist with player and coach development.
- o The LGFA permit a maximum of **2** other playing opportunities (**per region**) at U13/U15/U17 level outside what has been outlined.

A playing opportunity is defined as a non-competitive event involving 1 host County inviting no more than 3 additional Counties.

- o If a Province organises additional Festival Days on a regional basis for an age grade, then this is deemed as one playing opportunity i.e., if County attends two regional festivals days organised by the province, then this means County can only host or attend one further playing opportunity. Important how this is planned as Counties must keep within the max. 12 contact sessions per calendar year.

Minimum requirements for participation in Provincial or National Festival Days. Counties must commit to the PDP Pledge, which includes:

- Min 2 people at **ALL Coach Education PDP Webinars**
- Min 2 people at the **Provincial In-Person Coaching Day**
- Min 2 people at the **Pre-Festival Day Online Information Session**
- Min 2 people at the **PDP Referee Online Programme** to assist with Provincial & National Festival Days.
- Must commence your PDP **programme minimum of 6-weeks in advance** of the National/Provincial Festival Day for that age group and have completed minimum of **3 Sessions** within this timeframe.

PLEASE NOTE:

- Lack of engagement or failure to meet minimum requirements (as shown above) in the PDP could result in your County not being invited to Provincial/National Festival Days

What are the Structures Associated with Each Age Group?

U17 Player Development Programme

? **Regionalised** County Based Programme

? **Sessions / Quality over Quantity**

Maximum 12 contact days

- One of these days is your Provincial/National Festival Day. The other 11 contact sessions can be one the following:
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- **Note, a County may decide to conduct less than 12 contact sessions also.**
- Need to be creative when planning content to ensure cater for all key areas of development every time meet players.

? **Time of year (When should PDP Commence / Conclude)**

To be decided by County to

- Not disrupt club fixtures, maximise club participation and not coincide with other development initiatives.
- Tie in with Provincial/Regional Player Development Programme Festival Days

NOTE:

- Full Programme cannot commence until 1st February and must be completed by 1st October within a calendar year. All Counties must sign up to the PDP Pledge prior to commencement of the programme.

? **Who can attend?**

- o Open invite to all non-county players. A player who has made a County panel at U14, 16 and 18 grades within the calendar year are not eligible for the PDP.
- o Inclusive based on County capacity for coach / player ratio (min 1:8/max 1:10) (Players registered with a county panel cannot be selected to take part in the PDP programme)
- o The capacity should be set according to County resources, however, should **not** involve a selection process i.e., trials and should aim to have representation from all clubs i.e., clubs to nominate X number of players each according to number of coaches available.
- o Clubs should also be encouraged/requested to send in 1 mentor which will...

- Increase capacity.
- Be a mechanism for coach development and collaboration within the County!
- Could apply a ratio – for every 4 players a club sends into the PDP, they must provide one mentor (1:4)

? **Playing Opportunities**

- o The National U17 Festival Day will be **Non-**competitive.
- o National U17 Festival Day will be organised in the Summer to include coach education element, educational talks for players and players experiencing different game formats.
- o The LGFA permit a maximum of **2** other playing opportunity (**per region**) at U13/U15/U17 level outside what has been outlined for the National Festival Day.

A playing opportunity is defined as a non-competitive event involving 1 host County inviting no more than 3 additional Counties.

- **Minimum requirement to participate at Provincial/National Festival Days. Counties must sign up to the PDP Pledge to include:**
 - o Min 2 people at **ALL Coach Education PDP Webinars**
 - o Min 2 people at the **Provincial In-Person Coaching Day**
 - o Min 2 people at the **Pre-Festival Day Online Information Session**
 - o Min 2 people at the **PDP Referee Online Programme** to assist with Provincial & National Festival Days.
 - o Must commence your PDP **programme minimum of 6-weeks in advance** of the National/Provincial Festival Day for that age group and have completed minimum of **3 Sessions** within this timeframe.

PLEASE NOTE:

- Lack of engagement or failure to meet minimum requirements (as shown above) in the PDP could result in your County not being invited to Provincial/National Festival Days

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

What are the key requirements when recruiting PDP coaches?

It is important that all coaches participating in the PDP are prior checked for the following. **Preference will be given to those who:**

- Are a member of the LGFA
- Have relevant previous or current coaching experience. Candidate must have at least three years of coaching experience with Ladies Gaelic Football teams
- Be currently Garda/Access NI Vetted with Gaelic Games Code (3-year expiry)
- Completed Gaelic Games Safeguarding 1 Course (3-year expiry)
- Hold an Introduction to Coaching Gaelic Games Course or previous Foundation/FUNdamentals coaching award
 - It is recommended that coaches involved with the U17 PDP hold a LGFA Level 1 Coaching Award. Please note, this is not compulsory.
- Abide by the Gaelic Games Code of Behaviour

<https://ladiesgaelic.ie/lfa-hub/clubs/child-welfare-protection/code-of-behaviour/>

What are the requirements if recruiting a 'responsible adult'?

- The responsible adult, i.e., a person over 18 yrs. of age, if not a qualified coach, shall be deemed a Supervisor of Children.
- He/she must also be an LGFA member
- Have satisfactorily completed their vetting.
- Must have attended relevant Child Safeguarding Training as per above.

For PR purposes, what terminology should we use?

- For all social media posts and correspondence, Player Development Programme should be reference throughout to ensure consistency in messaging. Isolated wording like 'development' or 'development programme' or 'squads' should not be used.
- If getting training gear for your groups, then ensure 'Player Development Programme' is the term used as opposed to 'Development Squad'.

Can we conduct more than 12 contact sessions?

- The PDP should not supersede club activity hence maximum 12 contact sessions. Please note, these sessions do not need to run concurrently to ensure tie in with County games programme.
- Included in these 12 contact sessions are County/Provincial Festival Day as well as opportunity to be involved in **two** other playing opportunities (**per region**) where applicable.
- Please note that a County can conduct less than 12 contact sessions if required.

Time of Year (When should PDP Commence / Conclude)

To be decided by County to

- Not disrupt club fixtures, maximise club participation and not coincide with other development initiatives.
- Tie in with Provincial/County Player Development Programme Festival Days

NOTE:

Full Programme cannot commence until 1st February and must be completed by 1st October within a calendar year. All Counties must sign up to the PDP Pledge prior to commencement of the programme.

What is a 'Playing Opportunity' defined as?

- A playing opportunity is defined as a non-competitive event involving 1 host County inviting no more than 3 additional Counties.

What if we are unable to plan our coaching sessions to tie in with the Provincial/National Festival Days arranged?

- Each County are permitted to participate in an additional **two** playing opportunities per age group per region. This will provide flexibility for games opportunities if unable to participate in the Provincial/National Festival Days

How will we cater for bigger numbers? What if we don't have enough numbers?

- Prior Planning is key. Where numbers are large, the programme should be regionalised within your County
- The County programme should aim to include players from every club in the County, and every club should provide a coach for the County PDP project in turn.
- The PDP has the added dimension of Coach Education, and it is important to utilise this opportunity to develop coaches within the process
- If numbers are very small, liaise with the Development Team to decide whether appropriate to enter the Festival Day. This should not impact on coaching sessions

What if we have very big numbers? Do we bring everyone to each Festival Day?

- The development officer in your Province will monitor the numbers attending your sessions and will plan the regional or Provincial days accordingly to ensure everyone gets opportunity to be involved.
- There should be no selection or de-selection of players unless players commitment to the programme is not what it should be i.e., players only attend 20% of total sessions.
- The three playing opportunities will also allow Counties to be flexible in ensuring every player gets meaningful playing time.

With the big numbers, will this mean reduced playing time at the festival days?

- No, we aim to provide at least 80 minutes football for each team involved. Providing players with as much playing time will be a priority when planning the festival days.

With the big numbers, can a County organise an internal PDP with the conclusion of a County Festival Day?

- Yes, the option to run an internal PDP with the inclusion of a County PDP Festival Day is available to Counties. Please note that this would mean participation in the Provincial PDP Festival Day would not apply as a result.

- Organisation of an internal PDP would need to be discussed in advance with the relevant Provincial Development Officer to ensure the programme and the festival days are organised within PDP guidelines.
- Approval would need to be sought from National Development team.

Can we conduct any other U13/15/17 activity outside PDP Project?

- No, the only County activity permitted and sanctioned is the PDP for these age groups.
- Development activities organised for age groups lower than U13 i.e., U11/U12 are no longer permitted, and this time should be devoted to more club blitzes etc. to provide more football for all players.

What sanctions are in place if a County breach the PDP Project guidelines? What is a breach?

- A sanction of €500 per breach will apply to each County e.g., a County conducts more than 12 contact sessions at this age group for the PDP Project

If a County wants to organise additional playing opportunities, how do we go about this?

- A County may host a maximum of three Counties for a PDP Festival Day
- An online [County Festival Day approval form](#) must be completed by the host County at **least one week** in advance of the event.
- Permission will be granted once this form is received and verified.

Are Provinces permitted to organise development leagues for U13, 15 and U17?

- No, the only game opportunities are what are outlined via the PDP.
- Provinces may organise more than one Provincial Festival Day but this would be deemed as a playing opportunity for the counties that participate i.e. if County attends two regional festivals days organised by the Province, then this means County can only host or attend a further one playing opportunity. Important how this is planned as Counties must keep within the max. 12 contact sessions per calendar year.

What if we want to commence preparation early for our U14/16/U18 County Teams?

- The PDP project does not impinge on County Team Preparation
- If Counties want to hold trials, select players, organise subsequent training activities and challenge games etc. for these county age grades (Under 14,16,18) then this is permitted once the promotion of same is separate to PDP Project and named at those age grades.
- No Inter County Activity is permitted prior to 1st December.
- Trials/Selection sessions – maximum 1 session per week permitted during November for selection purposes only but this cannot be a challenge game against other opposition or collective training sessions for championship preparation
- Induction/Screening meetings –1 collective session permitted before 1st December. This cannot be a field-based session.
- The titles 'Academy' or 'Development Squad' are no longer permitted so important the above activity reflects the purpose of same i.e., when requesting permission for challenge games, it must be requested as U14/U16/U18 Inter

County Preparation

- No alternative U13/15/U17 County activity is permitted outside PDP.

What if a County does not want to participate in the PDP Project?

- It is a counties decision whether they organise a County PDP. Counties may run a PDP for selected age groups i.e., U13 only.

COSTS - Can Counties apply a player fee for the PDP programme?

- The PDP is designed to be inclusive, so any financial contribution from players should remain minimal and must not create profit for counties. If considering a fee, counties should have explored all other financial avenues initially. Such arrangements often reduce or remove the need for participant contributions and help sustain equitable access.
- Where unavoidable costs remain, a modest fee may be applied solely to cover essential items such as pitch hire, transport or equipment. Counties should present these costs transparently and share a clear breakdown with parents and players. **A capped flat rate, not exceeding €20 for a programme cycle**, may be applied, or alternatively a small per-session contribution, for example €2.
- In all cases, no player should be excluded on financial grounds, and counties should offer support mechanisms where assistance is needed.

Who do I contact to find out more about the Player Development Programme or to discuss any of the above items in this document:

U17 PDP National		
William Harmon	william.harmon@lgfa.ie	087 979 4955
Emily Martin	emily.martin@lgfa.ie	087 187 6212
U13/15 PDP Leinster		
Emily Jacob Harris	gdo.leinster@lgfa.ie	087 718 1300
U13/15 PDP Munster		
Gearoid Balfry	gdo.munster@lgfa.ie	083 353 4875
U13/15 PDP Connacht		
Connacht Contact	secretary.connacht@lgfa.ie	086 326 5911
U13/15 PDP Ulster		
Ciaran Murtagh	ciaran.murtagh.ulster@gaa.ie	+4477 9516 0979
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2026 PDP Dates

Dates of the PDP Coach Education Webinars.

- | | |
|---|---|
| • Induction Webinar | Monday, 19 th January 2026 |
| • Role Description/Coaching Climate Webinar | Wednesday, 11 th February 2026 |
| • Being a PDP Coach | Monday 2 nd March 2026 |
| • Planning a PDP Session | Monday, 25 th March 2026 |

Provincial In Person Coaching Days

- | | |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| • Munster PDP Coaching Day: | Friday, 17 th April 2026 |
| • Connacht PDP Coaching Day: | Saturday, 11 th April 2026 |
| • Leinster PDP Coaching Day: | Saturday, 25 th April 2026 |
| • Ulster PDP Coaching Day: | Saturday, 18 th April 2026 |

PDP Referee Online Session to assist with Provincial & National Festival Days

- July 2026
- Min age of participant:
 - 15+ and do not necessarily need to be a player or selected from the U15/17 PDP
 - Open to Male and Females

National and Provincial Festival Days:

- | | |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------|
| • National U17 Festival Day | 7 th July 2026 |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------|

U13 Provincial Festival Days

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|-------------|--|
| • Leinster: | Saturday, 8 th August 2026 |
| • Ulster: | Saturday, 9 th August 2026 |
| • Connacht: | Saturday, 11 th July 2026 |
| • Munster: | Saturday, 22 nd August 2026 |

U15 Provincial Festival Days

- | | |
|-------------|---|
| • Leinster: | Saturday, 22 nd August 2026 |
| • Ulster: | Saturday, 12 th September 2026 |
| • Connacht: | Saturday, 25 th July 2026 |
| • Munster: | Saturday, 29 th August 2026 |